

MAX CONQUERS SUZUKA

With Max Verstappen's victory at the Japanese Grand Prix, the battle for the Drivers' Championship is **now wide open.**

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There's no denying Max Verstappen's admiration for the Suzuka circuit. Back in 2022, when the Dutchman won the Japanese Grand Prix for the very first time, all the signs pointed towards a special relationship brewing between the two. In a three-hour-long, rain-hit race that featured barely 28 of the scheduled 53 laps, destiny came into play for Verstappen as he crossed the finish line to win not just the Grand Prix, but his second consecutive championship.

In 2023, Verstappen was already comfortably ahead of the pack in points, pace and position, and he single-handedly guided Red Bull to the Constructors' title. The 2024 race, held much earlier in the season, saw him zoom through a cherry-blossom-adorned Suzuka Circuit to victory.

However, this season's victory was sweeter than ever. The defending champion, who had been constantly lurking in the shadows of the top runner, finally pounced at the perfect opportunity to climb atop the podium. A four-month dry spell came to an end, and Verstappen had announced his title defence bid.

McLaren playing catch-up

It was starting to look like the McLaren duo of Lando Norris and Oscar Piastri would become an untouchable force. With a win apiece, they headed into the third race of the 2025 Formula One season with one undeniable element — confidence.

They dominated all three practice sessions and firmly established themselves at the top of the grid. Even during the crucial qualifying, the current championship leader Norris had

stitched together a terrific lap to all but guarantee himself pole.

However, in the dying moments of the session, Verstappen decided to switch gears. Zipping through the high-speed corners and demanding curves, he used every square of the track limits and whipped up a masterclass final lap to beat Norris by just over one-hundredth of a second.

Despite driving a Red Bull that was not fully up to scratch, the 27-year-old guided his car to the front of the grid. The Milton Keynes-based team was both shocked and elated; once again, their talisman had delivered.

What made it even more special was that it was Red Bull's final race with Honda in Japan. The resident engine manufacturer will partner Aston Martin in 2026, while Ford is set to power Red Bull. A seven-year relationship that delivered countless victories needed a fitting farewell, and it was up to Verstappen to see it through.

Action off-track

The build-up to the race revolved predominantly around the 'Max vs McLaren' storyline, but the second Red Bull driver was also the centre of

